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REPLY



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There is a long history about the roles and responsibilities of the ‘public intellectual’ (Hattie 2010). Said (1993), for example, argued that academics need to stand outside society and its institutions and actively disturb the status quo but at the same time address their concerns to as wide a public as possible. Indeed, in New Zealand it is legislated that academics are required to be the ‘critics and conscience’ of society. This requirement continues to be even more important and there should be little solace in academics hiding in academic journals talking to each other and refraining from public debate about matters within their expertise.

Alexander (2010) noted that there are four major reactions to academic debate, which he termed the four corrosive pretenders: the discourses of dichotomy, derision, myth and meaninglessness. The discourse of dichotomy reduces everything to mutual exclusives, the discourse of derision defines the tone of response (‘first misrepresent then ridicule it, personalizing the attack where possible and appealing to the lowest common denominator of popular prejudice’). The discourse of myth played out by many critics is that ‘it was not like this in my day’, ‘I did not teach this way’, ‘we did not have jargon or management-speak in our day’. The discourse of meaninglessness is about the destruction of language itself – ‘new initiatives, step changes, hitting the ground running, driving up standards, rolling out innovation, zero tolerance, best practice, world class schools, back to basics and the rest’. To these Eacott (2017) has added the discourse of the cult: ‘a person or thing that is popular or fashionable among a particular group or section of society’. The premise seems to be ‘bring down the cult and you bring down the research of the cult’.

Eacott (2017) claims there is a ‘cult of Hattie’ in Australia, and he takes much pain to note that his critique is not a personal attack, but about ‘the conditions which have facilitated the rise of a guru’. Like Eacott, I wonder why the ideas in Visible Learning have gained traction, been repeated, been critiqued, and been misinterpreted; but I have also watched in many schools the ideas been taken up, implemented, and welcomed. I am an avid collector of evidence of the impact on students in many schools that have implemented some of the VL ideas, have co-written a book on these outcomes (Hattie, Masters, and Birch

2016), and continue to update and modify the research as I learn from these implementations. Indeed, I have been at the forefront of critique of the fundamental notions in Visible Learning (see Chapter 10 of Hattie 2009), use one of the best critiques (Snook et al. 2009) as a text in my course, and have always seen critique as the essence of the academic contribution. Our discipline needs to be saturated with critique of ideas; and it should be welcomed. Every paradigm or set of conjectures should be tested to destruction and its authors, adherents, and users of the ideas should face public accountability. Thesis-antithesis-synthesis is well built into the water of academia. This surely should be the norm.

I have often noted in my writings that I have been most influenced by Popper (1959), and consider falsifiability and making bold conjectures as the essence of academic progress. VL contains many 'bold' conjectures (as requested by Popper), and thus they are readily falsifiable (as demanded by Popper). Yes, there have been critics of some of the data, re-interpretations from some of the meta-analyses, but so far no critique (that I know about) about the 'bold speculations' about seeing learning through the eyes of the students, enabling students to become their own teachers, the value of success criteria, the premise of 'Know thy impact' in its many forms, the role of relationships and trust to allow for error and misconceptions to come to the fore, about the power of giving and receiving feedback, the focus on learning strategies in the context of the subject domain, making schools inviting places for students to come and learn, and focusing on the learning lives of students.

These are the main ideas, although Eacott chooses to see the contribution more in terms of managerialism, research method, and dictums for non-critical people to blindly accept. Eacott claims interest in the 'point at which a programme/project moves from an innovation to a disruption in production and then a (social) movement'. He argues that educational leadership in Australia has submitted to a particular form of fad or fashion – the guru – and Australia has "almost to the point of saturation, reached a level where it can now be labelled the 'Cult of Hattie'". The 'brand Hattie' has, he claims, been 'uncritically adopted by the masses and spread across Australian education systems in a previously unmatched scope and scale'. The real irony here is that the key message in VL is that we want educators to evaluate the decisions they make – so if a school or district was to use the VL research then they should do so based on the evidence they have collected as to why and on its impact on their students. It would be contradictory for anyone to use the research blindly – it is the very thing the research is trying to change.

He makes three major claims. His first claim is that there are specific conditions that have enabled the rise of Cult Hattie. The main condition is that Australia is currently reform conscious and this reform is dominated by a rational/control approach concerned with a need to know 'what works'. This is, he writes, a Tayloristic pursuit of 'one right method' and 'all of a sudden, despite

years of school effectiveness and school improvement literature and calls for instructional leadership (including supporting empirical research), there was finally research that spoke to administrator rhetoric'. So along came Hattie, as his work 'brought a degree of scientific rigour and robustness to claims of "what works best"'. Eacott seems to deride rigour, robustness, and the 'pursuit of effectiveness and efficiency' as these, he claims, were 'central to Taylorism'. He uses many code words for negative impact: the atomising of evaluation, the constant generation of data, the post-Fordist models of management, and that I have 'become canonized in initial teacher education, graduate programmes, and professional dialogue and debate'. This will be a surprise to many in these sectors.

His second claim is that 'unlike past attempts at pedagogical reform, Hattie's work has provided school leaders with data that appeal to their administrative pursuits'. A synthesis of meta-analyses is based on many meta-analyses, which in turn are based on many thousands of empirical studies. These methods Eacott claims are 'unlike past attempts' but they have been part of our offerings for over 100 years; hardly novel. The notion that one academic's work has become canonised does not do service to the many in the public service of education who have made their own interpretations of the research. They are not automatons, or uncritical consumers of the research as painted in Eacott; far from it. There is indeed healthy 'due vigilance in assessing the worth of such approaches' as any search of Google and Google Scholar will attest. The extreme claims that the work is uncritically accepted by professional organisations like ACEL is easily countered with reference to their web page that lists many other speakers, papers, critics, and alternatives. I note it is Eacott, not ACEL nor educators or administrators across Australia that has tried 'to elevate that individual to guru status'. Surely, we all agree that 'what the Australian school leadership community arguably needs is more rigorous and robust work and more significantly, dialogue and debate (to which Hattie is a part) not the blind adherence to a single guru' – whether that guru is Hattie or Eacott.

Third, he argues that the cult of Hattie is a tragedy in Australian school leadership. It is hard to judge what this tragedy is – the hint is the 'uncritical adoption of any one position is problematic' and who would disagree with this but where is the evidence there is but one position? No fear, there are many critics, as there should be, to the ideas in VL.

One would certainly hope that the methods on which VL is mainly based, meta-analysis has a 'degree of perceived rigour and robustness' (and note, it was invented in education not medicine). But like all methods, it is a method – it is the interpretation that is made, the model that is built and defended, it is the counter evidence and unintended consequences that matter. Claiming it is mere empiricism misses the labour of love to interpret these numbers, discover the patterns, triangulate with other evidence, and making conjectures that are subject to falsifiability claims. The major focus was to change the debate from

'What works' to 'What works best' and subsequently I have argued that it is the local instantiation of high probability interventions that matters. It is the fidelity of implementation, it is the adjustment to local contexts, it is the collective agreement about what 'impact' means, and it is the skills of school leaders to tweak, change, and readjust in light of this evidence about the impact on students that matters most. Eacott misses this, but fortunately many commentators on VL seem to have grasped this clearly and see it as a strength. If VL has one main message it is that the expertise of the educators is at the forefront of our schools success, and we need to invest, esteem, and scale this expertise. This, for many, seems the novel core idea and it is why many have indicated why the VL story resonant so much with them. Eacott ignores this.

Conclusion

Eacott need not be concerned; there are many critics of my work; there are many department officials and politicians who use many other sources beside mine; there are teachers and school leaders who choose other than the messages in VL. Yes, there are many who find the interpretations and conjectures worthwhile but he can be assured if there is no evidence of implementing these ideas on the learning lives of students educators are quick to dismiss them. Educators are not uncritical believers of a cult figure.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author.

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